

5.2. Assessment of Significance

Having arrived at an understanding of the place through analysis of the relevant documentary records as well as the physical fabric of the place, the following assessment of the cultural significance of the site is made in accordance with the New South Wales State Heritage Criteria.

Criterion (a): An item is important in the course or pattern of NSW's (or the local area's) cultural or natural history.

The Waverley Memorial Hospital is historically significant as an example of planned benefaction, a form of philanthropy that saw 19th century suburban villas, mansions and estates donated in the early 20th century for use by social institutions for the public good.

The Methodist Church's establishment of a hospital as a memorial to the First World War is a prominent example of the expressions of commemoration which prevailed in Australian public and community building projects in the 1920s.

The site and 19th century residential buildings at the War Memorial Hospital reflect the history of subdivision and residential development of the area, in particular the construction of mansions within landscaped grounds by the wealthy merchant classes, buoyed by the stable economic conditions of the 1870s and 1880s.

The ongoing use since 1922 as a fully-equipped medical hospital offering nurses' training is of historical significance in the evolution of health care and services in suburban Sydney.

Criterion (b): An item has strong or special association with the life or works of a person, or a group of persons, of importance in NSW's (or the local area's) cultural or natural history.

The Edina estate is closely associated with the Vickery family, the prominent 19th century Sydney merchants and philanthropists who supported many works by the Methodist Church. The family's donation of the estate to the Methodist Church was made as a memorial to Ebenezer Vickery Jr.

As one of the most ambitious and substantial works ever carried out by the Methodist Church in NSW, the War Memorial Hospital has a strong and significant historical association with the Methodist and later with the Uniting Church.

Criterion (c): An item is important in demonstrating aesthetic characteristics and/or a high degree of creative or technical achievement in NSW (or the local area).

The War Memorial Hospital site is one of the largest remaining suburban Victorian spaces in eastern Sydney; its overall spatial order is still discernible through the site's topography, trees, scale and arrangement of buildings. It contains Edina, which is a very good and highly intact example of a Victorian mansion, which is a showpiece of Victorian architectural technology (vaulted and concreted verandah construction, cast ironwork, internal stairs). The three large Victorian houses (Ellerslie, Banksia, Wytchazel) built for family members, designed as a group and distinctively located along a private street, form a rare and very good example of a Victorian streetscape to two streets: the private street and Birrell Street.